LIN 3042 · Applied Linguistics · Fall 2026

Articles for the paper: overview

AI disclaimer. Content guided by Tommie Juzek; drafted upon his prompting and polished by an AI assistant (Claude Opus 5.5, Anthropic); reviewed and approved by Tommie Juzek.

These are the articles proposed in THA3 for the Article Summary & Critique, grouped by the course's areas. Each comes with what to watch out for: pointers for the critique part of your paper, not verdicts on the articles. **Pitched and approved** means a student proposed it in THA3 and it is approved for them (that student may be you). The twelve recommended articles are open to everyone, whoever pitched them. If you would like another article that is not yours, ask the instructor, as it may free up once its student has chosen. To switch to an article not listed here, pitch it first.

Three common things to check in any study Not a complete list, but three that come up again and again.

- **Correlation or cause?** Ask how people ended up in each group. If they chose their own condition (an app, a school, a class), the groups may differ in other ways too, such as motivation or family background, and those differences could explain the result. Only random assignment rules that out. Words like *affects*, *leads to* or *contributes to* in a study without random assignment are a claim to check, not a finding.
- **Could it be a false positive?** Small samples, many measures and analyses chosen after seeing the data make "significant" results easy to get by chance (Simmons, Nelson & Simonsohn, 2011). Look at the sample size, how many things were tested, and whether the study was preregistered or replicated. And a null result is not proof of no effect, especially in a small study.
- **Do you believe it because you want to?** Belief bias is the tendency to judge an argument by whether we like its conclusion (Evans, Barston & Pollard, 1983). Take extra care with pleasant or popular conclusions, such as "learning languages makes you smarter", "whales have language" or "a drink helps you speak": they need the same evidence as anything else.

Article	What to watch out for	Status
First language acquisition		
Messenger et al. (2026). Priming beyond syntax: Crosslinguistic evidence for shared syntactic and thematic representations in Polish–English bilingual children. *Journal of Memory and Language 151, 104799.* doi.org/10.1016/j.jml.2026.104799 also: Bilingualism	Dense and on the long side, so budget extra time, and learn the jargon first: structural priming, thematic roles, Polish word order and case (OVS). Within- and between-language priming, and children and adults, are compared across different groups, and some child effects are small, so check which comparisons are actually tested.	pitched and approved
Rabagliati & Robertson (2017). How do children learn to avoid referential ambiguity? Insights from eye-tracking. *Journal of Memory and Language 94, 15–27.* doi.org/10.1016/j.jml.2016.09.007 also: Psycholinguistics	From 2017, older than the usual rule; the year has been waived for this one. The key child result sorts trials by what the children went on to say, which is a correlation inside an experiment, and some measures were changed after null results (the paper says so openly): a good case for discussing analytic flexibility. The adult groups are small (12).	pitched and approved

Article	What to watch out for	Status
Second language acquisition		
Alqarawi & Alshammari (2026). How do Arabic college students perceive AI in L2 poetry interpretation? *Asian-Pacific Journal of Second and Foreign Language Education 11, article 34.* doi.org/10.1186/s40862-026-00410-y	A one-off survey of students' opinions (202 students), so its paths show how opinions go together, not what causes what. Read closely: the Abstract calls AI "minimally effective", while the Conclusion says students saw it working "beyond surface-level pattern matching"; check whether the learner types in the Discussion are backed by a measure in the Method; and the data are not shared. Expect extra critique work.	pitched and approved
Barbour & Debreli (2026). Exploring the psychological dimensions of poetry- and drama-based instruction in EFL learning. *Frontiers in Psychology 17, 1802084.* doi.org/10.3389/fpsyg.2026.1802084	An interview study (focus groups with 24 students, interviews with 6 teachers): it shows how participants describe poetry and drama lessons, not whether anxiety actually fell. Participants were chosen because they already use these methods, so look at the interview questions in the Appendix: do any assume a benefit? A pleasant conclusion, so watch for belief bias. Expect extra critique work.	pitched and approved
Cieśla et al. (2025). The impact of orthography versus images on foreign language learning: Evidence from behavioral and neural markers. *Bilingualism: Language and Cognition 29(3), 563–575.* doi.org/10.1017/S1366728925100242 also: Neurolinguistics	A focused lab experiment (40 new words, tested 24 hours later, with brain responses), so much of the work is placing it in context: should new words be taught with pictures or with written translations? Read up on the picture superiority effect, dual coding and the N400 first. A strength: it reports a power analysis, which few papers here do.	pitched and approved
Cruz & Suethanapornkul (2025). Second language learners' sensitivity to grammatical gender in Spanish–English codeswitching environments. *Second Language Research 41(4), 743–767.* doi.org/10.1177/02676583251314000 also: Bilingualism	A small sample (26 learners). The authors conclude that learners are "not sensitive" to gender in these switches, but their own figures (86% expected answers for masculine nouns, 45% for feminine ones) could also be read as a strong masculine bias plus some sensitivity: worth checking which reading the data support.	pitched and approved
Kim et al. (2026). Comparing the effectiveness of Duolingo, classroom instruction, and classroom + Duolingo instruction conditions on beginner-level French language development. *Studies in Second Language Acquisition 48(3), 680–707.* doi.org/10.1017/S0272263126101521	Groups were not randomised: classroom students chose whether to add Duolingo, and the app-only learners were recruited separately and were much older (average age 42, against 19 and 22). So ask: do keen learners choose the combination, rather than the combination making them better? The headline is a *null* result, and "no significant difference" is not the same as "equally effective" without an equivalence test. The study was funded by Duolingo, as the paper states. Many readers would like apps to work as well as class, so this is also a case for belief bias.	pitched and approved
Kuperman (2025). How does language distance affect reading fluency and comprehension in English as second language? *Studies in Second Language Acquisition 47(3), 757–773.* doi.org/10.1017/S027226312510065X also: Psycholinguistics	Big claims (a "mechanism") from observational data at a single point in time: a mediation analysis on such data can fit a causal story but cannot show one. Language distance comes bundled with country, university and testing site; the effects are small; and "no effect on comprehension" rests on a non-significant result. Big claims require big evidence: check how far the design carries them. The conclusion is intuitive (the paper itself opens with "Intuitively"), which makes it easy to accept on plausibility alone: a case for belief bias.	pitched and approved

Article	What to watch out for	Status
Maie & Godfroid (2025). Testing the three-stage model of second language skill acquisition. *Studies in Second Language Acquisition 47(2), 617–649.* doi.org/10.1017/S027226312500021X	Mostly careful about causation: the learning abilities were measured, not manipulated, and the Abstract says *correlated*. Watch for places in the Discussion that slip into causal wording (*contributed to*, *crucial role*). Long (33 pages) but readable: one group of 65 learners and an artificial language.	pitched and approved
Mehmood et al. (2025). Psychological impact of languages on the human mind: Research on the contribution of psycholinguistics approach to teaching and learning English. *Journal of Applied Linguistics and TESOL 8(3), 1160–1174.* doi.org/10.63878/jalt1089	Raises questions at first glance, so budget for extra critique work. Look into the venue (not on the syllabus list: how does the journal review its papers?) and the authors (what else have they published, and where?), and check the references: do the DOIs lead to the papers cited? A survey with interviews, so the correlations it reports ($r = 0.58$ and $r = -0.47$) show what goes together, not what causes what. Compare what the Method says will be done (it is written in the future tense) with what the Results report, and check which variables were actually measured.	pitched and approved
Renner et al. (2017). Dutch courage? Effects of acute alcohol consumption on self-ratings and observer ratings of foreign language skills. *Journal of Psychopharmacology 32(1), 116–122.* doi.org/10.1177/0269881117735687	From 2017; the year has been waived for this one. A real randomised experiment, but small (25 per group), and the control drink was water, so participants knew whether they had had alcohol and expectations could play a part (the authors say so). The headline, better pronunciation, was not the authors' prediction (they expected worse ratings), comes from one of several exploratory tests, and has $p = .05$ (.051 unrounded): a textbook case for false-positive psychology. A fun conclusion, so watch for belief bias. Short (7 pages).	pitched and approved
Şafak & Hopp (2025). Learning L2 grammar from prediction errors? Verb biases in structural priming in comprehension and production. *Bilingualism: Language and Cognition 28(5), 1249–1265.* doi.org/10.1017/S1366728925000033 also: ■ Psycholinguistics	Very solid but dense: learn the dative alternation, the visual-world paradigm and cluster-based permutation tests first. The claim of "longer-term learning" rests on a before/after comparison without a control group, so it is the weakest link; the verb-bias effect itself is robust.	pitched and approved
■ Bilingualism		
Chamorro, de la Viña & Janke (2025). The effects of L2 exposure at school on the cognitive development of children from monolingual backgrounds: A longitudinal study. *Bilingualism: Language and Cognition 29(4), 829–843.* doi.org/10.1017/S1366728925100448	Families chose the schools, and the immersion school is also the only private one, so school choice and family background could explain the differences; the authors themselves note that higher English exposure already went with better scores at the first test. Read it next to the large meta-analyses that find little or no reliable bilingual advantage once publication bias is corrected (for children: Lowe et al., 2021), and the course side note on the benefits of bilingualism. Many people want this conclusion to be true: a classic case for belief bias.	pitched and approved
García González, Lahdenranta & Lehtonen (2025). Are executive functions engaged in language switching? The role of language proficiency. *Bilingualism: Language and Cognition 29(2), 516–526.* doi.org/10.1017/S1366728925100199	Correlational: executive functions and proficiency were measured, not manipulated, so "engaged" is an inference from how two tasks go together. The key result rests on one interaction ($p = .027$) and smaller subgroups, so treat it as promising rather than settled. Its review section is a good map of the bilingual-advantage debate.	pitched and approved

Article	What to watch out for	Status
Koronkiewicz (2025). Adverb position in heritage and L2 Spanish–English code-switching. *Borealis: An International Journal of Hispanic Linguistics 14(2), 357–384.* doi.org/10.7557/1.14.2.8165	The groups (heritage speakers, L2 learners) are compared as they come, not assigned. Ratings were analysed as z-scores, so check how the conclusion that the groups do not differ was actually tested. Only four adverbs were used. Long in pages, but in large type.	pitched and approved
Mavrou et al. (2026). Cognition and emotion in moral decision-making: The role of working memory, emotional intelligence, and language factors in bilinguals' moral judgments and emotions. *Studies in Second Language Acquisition 48(2), 424–449.* doi.org/10.1017/S0272263125101484 also: Psycholinguistics	A tricky topic that needs careful reading: does deciding a moral dilemma in a second language change the choice? They mostly find no effect. A null result in one study means "no clear evidence either way", not proof of no effect, and the earlier positive findings deserve the same scrutiny, since small samples and flexible analyses produce false positives. A strength: it is preregistered. The ability results are correlational, so read "influenced" as "was associated with", and check that the Abstract's inhibition result ("only in their L1") matches the results tables.	pitched and approved
Rosales & Torres (2024). The role of metalinguistic knowledge in third-language development among heritage and late bilinguals. *International Journal of Bilingualism 29(3), 566–582.* doi.org/10.1177/13670069241229161 also: Second language	Metalinguistic knowledge (MK) was measured, not manipulated, so "MK significantly contributed to" (a phrasing the paper uses often) means "went together with", not "caused", and the paper does not say so. Check the statistics carefully, too: some reported values look inconsistent (for example, $t = -23.5$ next to a small effect size, $d = 0.29$). Online in 2024; it appeared in a 2025 issue, so it counts as 2025.	pitched and approved
Psycholinguistics		
Sidhu, Parajuli & Muraki (2026). That sounds exciting! Emotional iconicity facilitates processing and recall. *Journal of Memory and Language 150, 104769.* doi.org/10.1016/j.jml.2026.104769	Congruent words were selected, not created, so other word properties could differ: the authors match many (length, frequency, valence, concreteness) but not all (for example, age of acquisition). The effects are small (about 20–25 ms) but replicated in a second experiment with a power analysis. For memory, read past the title: the recall results are mixed across the three tests.	pitched and approved
Computational linguistics		
Lim et al. (2025). Format inertia: A failure mechanism of LLMs in medical pre-consultation. *Proceedings of EMNLP 2025: Industry Track, 1437–1450.* doi.org/10.18653/v1/2025.emnlp-industry.101	A strength: the causal claim is backed by an intervention (retraining on rebalanced data), across several models. Things to check: each model seems to have been trained only once, with no statistical tests; the patients were simulated; and clinical usefulness was judged by a language model. Short main text, with an appendix.	pitched and approved
Salim et al. (2025). MedCOD: Enhancing English-to-Spanish medical translation of large language models using enriched chain-of-dictionary framework. *Findings of the Association for Computational Linguistics: EMNLP 2025, 6579–6597.* doi.org/10.18653/v1/2025.findings-emnlp.350	A specialised engineering paper (machine translation of medical texts), so expect background work: BLEU, chrF++ and COMET scores, LoRA fine-tuning and the UMLS database. The test set is small (100 sentences), some margins over GPT-4o are tiny, and "clinical accuracy" is claimed without a human evaluation. Potentially challenging: read with extra care.	pitched and approved

Article	What to watch out for	Status
Salminen et al. (2025). Decoding deception in the online marketplace: Enhancing fake review detection with psycholinguistics and transformer models. *Journal of Marketing Analytics 14(3), 731–748.* doi.org/10.1057/s41270-025-00393-8 also: ■ **Psycholinguistics**	Validity is in the method details. The fake reviews were written on request by online participants ("Pretend to be an owner of this phone"), each followed by a real one, so they may differ from fakes in the wild. Many word-category tests were run, and reviews by the same writer may sit in both training and test data. Check the claim of "overly positive language" in fakes against the paper's own sentiment table.	**pitched and approved**
Wilcox et al. (2025). Bigger is not always better: The importance of human-scale language modeling for psycholinguistics. *Journal of Memory and Language 144, 104650.* doi.org/10.1016/j.jml.2025.104650 also: ■ **First language**	The instructor advises against this one for the paper: it is partly a position paper and partly a report on a shared task (the BabyLM Challenge), so it does not fit the standard criteria and would be a heavy extra load. Come and talk to the instructor first if you really want it.	**ask the instructor first**

Years are the year of first (online) publication; some articles have since appeared in a later issue, so cite them the way the journal's own "Cite this article" line does. References cited above: Evans, J. St. B. T., Barston, J. L., & Pollard, P. (1983). On the conflict between logic and belief in syllogistic reasoning. *Memory & Cognition, 11*(3), 295–306. Lowe, C. J., Cho, I., Goldsmith, S. F., & Morton, J. B. (2021). The bilingual advantage in children's executive functioning is not related to language status: A meta-analytic review. *Psychological Science, 32*(7), 1115–1146. Simmons, J. P., Nelson, L. D., & Simonsohn, U. (2011). False-positive psychology. *Psychological Science, 22*(11), 1359–1366. All references checked on 9 October 2026.